gatherers known as the Kanikkar mentioned in Chapter 1. It seems that when the oldest member of the Kanikkar, said to be 105 years old, was questioned by researchers he declared that his people knew these mountains as Thiruvana Malai because they had been named after one of their own, the poet-saint Thiruvalluvar. According to the old man, Thiruvalluvar had been born there and had ruled the area as its king, frequently roaming through the hills with his wife in search of honey. After his death the Kanikkar people had added Thiruvalluvar to their gods and continued to worship him to the present day.

But then other South Indian communities also claim Thiruvalluvar as one of theirs, including Jains, Buddhists and Shaivas. These claims make the point that Thiruvalluvar stands for Tamil and Dravidian identity. He is the South's champion in the face of advancing Sanskritisation from the North.

Here Thiruvalluvar's first English translator, Francis Ellis, deserves a further mention. Ellis's career as a civil servant got off to a disastrous start when as a young judge and magistrate in Thanjavur (known to the British as Tanjore) in 1805 he attempted to arrest a servant of the Raja of Tanjore who was alleged to have tortured a plaintiff by putting crushed chillies in his eyes. The enraged raja's protest to the government led to Ellis being posted to Masulipatnam in Telugu-speaking country, where he had the good fortune to meet the Telugu scholar Mamadi Venkayya, who directed him towards Telugu and Tamil literature. He is also said to have adopted local customs, including the wearing of 'native' dress.

In 1810 Ellis was forgiven and made Collector of Madras, where he was instrumental in setting up the College of Fort St George. This was in emulation of the East India Company's (EICo's) College of Fort William in Calcutta, where local pandits taught the vernacular languages to newly appointed civil servants very much to the benefit of